

Medicare in Plain English - Printable Checklists and Worksheets

From *Medicare in Plain English: The 2027 Guide* by Daniel Marsh (Oro Enigma Publishing). Print as many copies as you need.

E1 - Turning 65 checklist

Item	Date / answer	Done
My 65th birthday month		
My Initial Enrollment Period (3 months before to 3 months after)	from _____ to _____	
Am I already receiving Social Security? (If yes, the card comes automatically)		
Do I have group coverage from current employment (mine or my spouse's)?		
If yes: does the employer have 20		

or more employees? (confirmed in writing)		
If yes: is the drug coverage creditable? (letter kept)		
Am I contributing to an HSA? (stop 6 months before enrolling in any part of Medicare)		
Decision: Part A at 65?		
Decision: Part B at 65, or delay under the employer SEP?		
Decision: Part D at 65, or delay (creditable coverage)?		
Decision: Original Medicare + Medigap, or Advantage? (Chapter 11 read)		
Medigap quotes requested (3 insurers, same plan letter)		
Applied for Medicare		

(ssa.gov/medicare) on		
Card received; dates checked		
Medicare account created		
Premium payment set up (Easy Pay)		
Medigap applied for (within the 6- month window) on		
Part D plan chosen (Plan Finder) on; plan name and ID		
Old coverage cancelled (only after new coverage started)		
Welcome to Medicare visit booked		
Authorization forms (CMS-10106, CMS-1696) signed		

E2 - Employer plan versus Medicare: a yearly cost comparison

	Employer plan (for me / for us)	Medicare (Part B + Medigap + Part D)
Monthly premium x 12		Part B \$2,435 (2026) per person + Medigap _____ + Part D _____
Deductible(s)		Part B \$283; Medigap covers the rest (Plan G)
Typical year's copays and coinsurance		Plan G: \$0; Plan N: about \$20 per visit
Drug costs in a typical year		Part D copays (Plan Finder estimate)
Worst-case year	Plan's out-of- pocket maximum:	Plan G: \$283 + Part D cap \$2,100
Covers a spouse under 65?		No
Total, typical year		
Total, worst year		

E3 - Original Medicare or Advantage: the decision sheet

Answer each honestly. More ticks in the left column points to Original Medicare with Medigap; more in the right, to Advantage; and question 8 can override everything.

Question	Points left	Points right
1. Can I afford \$150-\$250 a month, rising with age, for Medigap?	Yes	No
2. Do I have or expect a serious or complex condition?	Yes	No
3. Are all my doctors and my hospital in the plan's network (confirmed by phone)?	No	Yes
4. Do I travel, winter elsewhere, or might I move?	Yes	No
5. Do I want dental, vision and hearing benefits enough to accept a network?	No	Yes
6. Am I comfortable with referrals, approvals and appeals?	No	Yes
7. Do I have	No	Yes (D-SNP)

Medicaid or qualify for a Medicare Savings Program?		
8. Does my state let me buy Medigap later without health questions (birthday rule, year-round)?	If no: buy Medigap now if ever	If yes: trying Advantage is low-risk
Totals		

E4 - Medicare Advantage plan comparison

	Plan 1	Plan 2	Plan 3
Plan name and type (HMO/PPO)			
Monthly premium / Part B giveback			
Star rating			
In-network out-of-pocket limit			
Combined limit (PPO)			
My primary doctor in network? (phone)			
My specialists in network? (phone)			
My hospital in network?			
Specialist copay			
Hospital copay per day, and days			
ER copay			

From Medicare in Plain English by Daniel Marsh (Oro Enigma Publishing). Free for personal use. oroenigma.com/medicare

Scan (MRI/CT) copay			
Skilled nursing per day (days 1- 20 / 21-100)			
Physical therapy per visit			
Part B drugs / chemo coinsurance			
Prior authorization list reviewed (EOC)			
My drugs: yearly cost (Plan Finder)			
Dental: annual max; my dentist in network?			
Vision / hearing / OTC / gym: what I would use			
Out-of-area coverage			
Total estimated yearly cost,			

typical year			
Worst-case yearly cost (limit + drug cap + premiums)			

E5 - Medigap quote comparison (same plan letter)

	Insurer 1	Insurer 2	Insurer 3
Plan letter			
Monthly premium at my age			
Pricing method (community / issue-age / attained-age)			
Rate increases, each of the last 5 years			
Household discount			
A.M. Best rating			
State complaint ratio			
Premium at 75 on the current table			
Notes (agent, service, crossover billing)			

E6 - Part D plan comparison

	Current plan	Plan A	Plan B
Plan name and ID			
Monthly premium			
Deductible			
Star rating			
All my drugs covered?			
Restrictions on my drugs (PA / step / quantity)			
My pharmacy preferred?			
Mail order available			
Estimated total yearly cost (Plan Finder)			
Month I would reach the cap			

E7 - The annual review checklist (October 15 to December 7)

Step	Done	Notes
ANOC read; changes marked		
Plan Finder run with current drug list		Current plan next- year cost: _____ Best alternative: _____
Advantage: doctors and hospital confirmed by phone for next year		
Advantage: out-of- pocket limit and copays compared with 2 alternatives		
Medigap: premium compared with 3 quotes; state rule checked		
IRMAA letter checked; appeal filed if income fell		
Decision made and enrollment submitted on		
Plan name, ID and estimated cost recorded		

Confirmation letter filed		
------------------------------	--	--

E8 - IRMAA appeal worksheet (form SSA-44)

Tax year Social Security used	
Income figure on the letter (MAGI)	
Life-changing event (marriage, divorce, death of spouse, work stoppage, work reduction, loss of property income, loss of pension, employer settlement)	
Date of the event	
Evidence I will attach	
My estimated MAGI for this year	
My estimated MAGI for next year	
Form filed on / how (online, mail, office)	
Decision received on / result	

E9 - My medicines

Drug (brand and generic)	Strength	How many, how often	Prescriber	Pharmacy	Part D tier / restriction	Monthly cost

E10 - My doctors and providers

Name	Specialty	Practice / phone	Accepts assignment?	In my plan's network? (date checked)

E11 - Appeal log

Date	What was denied	Reason given	Level	Filed on	Deadline	Decision	Next step

E12 - The hospital card

Keep with the Medicare card. Ask on day one, and each day:

Question	Answer / date
Am I an inpatient or under observation?	
If observation: has my doctor considered admission?	
Have I been given the Medicare Outpatient Observation Notice (MOON)?	
Have I been given "An Important Message from Medicare"? (QIO number: _____)	
Planned discharge date	
Will I need skilled nursing or rehab after? Have I had 3 inpatient midnights?	
Advantage: has prior authorization for the rehab / SNF been requested and approved?	
To appeal a discharge: call the QIO before midnight on the discharge day	

E13 - The phone-call card

Keep by the phone.

- Medicare does not call to sell, and never asks for my Medicare number.
- Did I start this contact? If not, I hang up.
- "Send it to me in writing with the company's name, and I will check it on [medicare.gov](https://www.medicare.gov)."
- No free braces, tests, supplies or "new cards".
- If I gave out my number by mistake: 1-800-MEDICARE (1-800-633-4227) and the Senior Medicare Patrol, 1-877-808-2468.

E14 - Where everything is

Medicare number (last 4) and card location	
Medicare account login (where written)	
Medigap insurer, policy number, phone	
Part D or Advantage plan, member number, phone	
Primary doctor, phone	
SHIP number for my state	
Person authorized on CMS-10106	
Person named on CMS-1696	
Folder location for MSNs, EOBs, bills, ANOCs	